ÉCLAIRS

MAKES	ACTIVE TIME	TOTAL TIME	OVEN
12 éclairs	**45 min**	**about 2 h, with the pastry cream already made and cold**	**425F / 220C for 10 min, then 375F / 190C for 12 min**

INGREDIENTS

120 ml	Nonfat milk
120 ml	Water
115 g	Unsalted butter
1 tsp	Sugar
1/4 tsp	Salt
140 g	All-purpose flour
5	Eggs, large
115 g	Bittersweet chocolate, coarsely chopped
120 ml	Heavy cream, for the glaze
1 tbsp	Light corn syrup
300 ml	Pastry cream, cold

METHOD

1. Make the pastry cream in advance and chill it hard. It has to be properly cold to pipe.
2. Heat the oven to 425F / 220C. Butter a baking sheet, or line one with parchment paper.
3. Combine the milk, water, butter, sugar and salt in a heavy saucepan over medium heat. Bring it to a rolling boil, by which point the butter will have melted away.
4. Add all the flour in one go and beat it hard with a wooden spoon. Carry on about 3 minutes, until the paste pulls together into a smooth mass, lets go of the pan sides, and has dried out a little.
5. Scrape it into a stand mixer bowl fitted with the paddle, or a heatproof bowl to work by hand.
6. On medium-high speed, beat in the eggs one at a time, each fully absorbed before the next one goes in. The finished paste is thick, smooth and shiny. A wooden spoon handles it the same way.
7. Load a piping bag fitted with a 12 mm plain tip, no. 6 or 7, putting in only as much paste as is comfortable to handle.
8. Pipe fingers 12 cm long and 2.5 cm wide, spaced about 5 cm apart. Should a stroke finish with a bulge or a tail, flatten it away with a wet fingertip.
9. Bake about 10 minutes, until they have puffed and are just beginning to colour.
10. Take the oven down to 375F / 190C and give them about 12 minutes more, until the shells are browned all over, hollow inside, and surprisingly light when you pick one up.
11. Out of the oven, drive a metal skewer into the end of each shell to open a small vent for the steam. Skip this and the shells cave in. Cool them on wire racks.
12. Make the glaze. Put the chopped chocolate and the corn syrup, which is there for shine, into a heatproof bowl. Bring the cream up in a small pan until it is just about to boil, then pour it over. Leave it alone for about 2 minutes while the chocolate melts, then stir gently with a rubber spatula, working in as little air as you can, until it is smooth and glossy. Let it cool to barely warm.
13. Stir the cold pastry cream smooth and load it into a piping bag with a plain tip that has a very small opening.
14. Fill each shell through the vent hole until it feels heavy in the hand. Open a second hole at the other end and fill from both ends when the cream will not travel the length of a shell, which happens where pockets have formed inside.
15. Take each filled éclair and dip its top into the glaze, shake it gently to let the excess run off, and stand it the right way up on a wire rack until the glaze firms.
16. Serve them immediately, or refrigerate for up to 6 hours.

NOTES

Fill the shells as soon as they are cool enough to handle, and eat them the day they are filled.
Every bump and wobble in the piping is exaggerated by the bake, so a good shell starts with good piping. The paste is forgiving — scoop up a bad finger and pipe it again, and smooth small bumps away with a dampened fingertip.
There is a split-and-fill route as well. Halve the cooled shells with a serrated knife, dip the top halves in the glaze and leave them on a rack to set, spoon pastry cream into the bottoms, then put the glazed tops back on.
Unfilled shells freeze wrapped tightly for up to 3 weeks. Crisp them straight from the freezer at 450F / 230C for about 10 minutes, then cool them before filling.
Matcha pastry cream works in place of the plain, and a matcha glaze in place of the chocolate.

FILLING

Pastry Cream

Makes: 600 ml / Active Time: 25 min / Rest: 10 min off the heat, then chilled / Total Time: 40 min plus chilling

INGREDIENTS

480 ml	Whole milk
1/2 bean	Vanilla bean
1/4 tsp	Salt
115 g	Sugar
30 to 35 g	Cornstarch
2	Eggs, large
60 g	Unsalted butter

METHOD

1. Set a bowl on the counter and rest a fine-mesh sieve in its rim. The cream lands there later, so it needs to be ready before anything goes on the heat.
2. Measure the milk into a heavy saucepan, anything but aluminium. Split the half bean lengthwise, scrape the seeds out with the tip of a knife straight into the milk, and add the salt.
3. Bring the milk up over medium-high heat to just short of boiling. Stir every so often and sweep the base of the pan, because the solids settle there and scorch. A bigger batch needs more attention.
4. Meanwhile whisk the sugar and cornstarch together in a mixing bowl. Take the full 35 g of cornstarch for a firm cream that holds a cut slice, and 30 g for everything else.
5. Break the eggs in and whisk until no lumps remain.
6. Ladle roughly a third of the scalding milk into the eggs in a slow stream, whisking the whole time. A lightly damp towel under the bowl steadies it and frees both hands.
7. Return it to the remaining milk on the stove. Whisk over a medium flame for roughly 2 minutes, until the body matches softly whipped cream.
8. Bring it just to the edge of a boil so the starch cooks out fully. A few slow bubbles breaking the surface is the target. A hard boil will curdle it.
9. Take the pan off the heat at once and push the cream through the sieve into the waiting bowl. Left sitting in the hot pan it keeps cooking.
10. Give it 10 minutes to drop in temperature, stirring now and then so heat escapes and no skin sets on top.
11. Cut the butter into four pieces. At around 60C, whisk them in one at a time, each piece disappearing completely before the next goes in.
12. Press plastic wrap flat against the surface of the cream and refrigerate. To cool it fast, spread it in a shallow dish first and wrap it the same way.

NOTES

Never use an aluminium pan. The yolks react with the metal and the cream turns grey.
Scorched milk ruins the whole batch and cannot be rescued. If dark spots appear on the pan bottom, taste the milk and start over if it has gone acrid.
The gap between properly thick and curdled is a matter of seconds. A cream that has gone only slightly grainy will sometimes come back with an immersion or countertop blender, though not reliably.
Two whole eggs give a lighter cream than the all-yolk French versions. Four yolks in place of the eggs makes a richer one.
Whisking the cream once it is cold breaks the starch down and thins it, so handle it gently from then on. Well covered, it keeps 5 days in the refrigerator.